# Question ID: b6560e5a

| Assessment | Test | Domain | Skill | Difficulty |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| SAT | Reading and Writing | Standard English Conventions | Boundaries | Medium |

**Question**

Materials scientist Marie-Agathe Charpagne and her colleagues believed they could improve on the multicomponent alloy NiCoCr, an equal-proportions mixture of nickel (Ni), cobalt (Co), and chromium (Cr), by replacing chromium with ruthenium _____ the alloy that resulted, NiCoRu, turned out to be an unsuitable replacement for NiCoCr.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

**Answer**

A. (Ru)

B. (Ru) but

C. (Ru),

D. (Ru), but

**Correct Answer: D**

**Rationale**

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses. This choice correctly uses a comma and the coordinating conjunction “but” to join the first main clause (“Materials…Ru”) and the second main clause (“the alloy…NiCoCr”).

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because when coordinating two longer main clauses such as these, it’s conventional to use a comma before the coordinating conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses.

# Question ID: 403d7bb5

| Assessment | Test | Domain | Skill | Difficulty |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| SAT | Reading and Writing | Standard English Conventions | Boundaries | Medium |

**Question**

According to Naomi Nakayama of the University of Edinburgh, the reason seeds from a dying dandelion appear to float in the air while _____ is that their porous plumes enhance drag, allowing the seeds to stay airborne long enough for the wind to disperse them throughout the surrounding area.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

**Answer**

A. falling,

B. falling:

C. falling;

D. falling

**Correct Answer: D**

**Rationale**

Choice D is the best answer. The word “falling” occurs in the middle of a clause and isn’t part of a supplement, so we don’t need any punctuation after it. We can see this more clearly if we simplify the rest of the sentence: “The reason seeds appear to float while falling is that their plumes enhance drag.” .

Choice A is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. The word “falling” occurs in the middle of a clause and isn’t part of a supplement, so we don’t need any punctuation after it. We can see this more clearly if we simplify the sentence: “The reason seeds appear to float while falling is that their plumes enhance drag.” . Choice B is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. The word “falling” occurs in the middle of a clause and isn’t part of a supplement, so we don’t need any punctuation after it. We can see this more clearly if we simplify the sentence: “The reason seeds appear to float while falling is that their plumes enhance drag.” . Choice C is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. The word “falling” occurs in the middle of a clause and isn’t part of a supplement, so we don’t need any punctuation after it. We can see this more clearly if we simplify the sentence: “The reason seeds appear to float while falling is that their plumes enhance drag.” .

# Question ID: 6b49f5f1

| Assessment | Test | Domain | Skill | Difficulty |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| SAT | Reading and Writing | Standard English Conventions | Boundaries | Medium |

**Question**

In 1727, dramatist Lewis Theobald presented a new play, *Double Falsehood*, at a London theater. Theobald claimed that his drama was based on a little-known play by William Shakespeare, *Cardenio*. Many, including poet Alexander Pope, were _____ historians have determined that Shakespeare's company did perform a play called *Cardenio* in 1613.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

**Answer**

A. skeptical but

B. skeptical, but

C. skeptical,

D. skeptical

**Correct Answer: B**

**Rationale**

Choice B is the best answer. There are two independent clauses in the sentence, each with a subject and a verb: "many...were skeptical" and "historians have determined…." These clauses can be grammatically joined by a comma and the coordinating conjunction "but."

Choice A is incorrect. This choice results in a run-on sentence, which occurs when two independent clauses are joined without punctuation. Two independent clauses can't be joined by just the coordinating conjunction "but." A comma would also be required. Choice C is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error called a comma splice. This sentence contains two independent clauses ("Many…were skeptical" and "historians have determined…"). A comma alone can't join two independent clauses. That requires a comma and a coordinating conjunction. Choice D is incorrect. This choice results in a run-on sentence, which occurs when two independent clauses are joined without punctuation. This sentence contains two independent clauses ("Many…were skeptical" and "historians have determined…"), which need to be either joined by a semicolon, joined by a comma and a coordinating conjunction, or separated by a period.

# Question ID: 5cc85f01

| Assessment | Test | Domain | Skill | Difficulty |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| SAT | Reading and Writing | Standard English Conventions | Boundaries | Medium |

**Question**

A conceptual artist and designer embraced by both the art world and the fashion _____ Mary Ping was chosen to curate the exhibition *Front Row: Chinese American Designers* for the Museum of Chinese in America.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

**Answer**

A. world

B. world:

C. world;

D. world,

**Correct Answer: D**

**Rationale**

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between a supplementary phrase and a main clause. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the supplementary phrase (“A conceptual artist…world”), which describes Mary Ping, and the main clause (“Mary…America”).

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the supplementary phrase (“A conceptual artist…world”) and the main clause (“Mary…America”) with appropriate punctuation. Choice B is incorrect because a colon can’t be used in this way to join the supplementary phrase (“A conceptual artist…world”) and the main clause (“Mary…America”). In this context, the colon incorrectly suggests that the information in the supplementary phrase is an explanation or amplification of the information in the main clause (Mary Ping being chosen to curate the exhibition), which isn’t the case. Choice C is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the supplementary phrase (“A conceptual artist…world”) and the main clause (“Mary…America”). Semicolons are conventionally used to separate two main clauses or to separate items in a complex series.

# Question ID: 40c3589d

| Assessment | Test | Domain | Skill | Difficulty |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| SAT | Reading and Writing | Standard English Conventions | Boundaries | Medium |

**Question**

Luci Tapahonso is the inaugural poet laureate of the Navajo Nation. Her book *Sáanii Dahataal/The Women Are Singing*—a combination of fiction and memoir, poetry and _____ serves as a testament to her versatility as a writer.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

**Answer**

A. prose;

B. prose

C. prose,

D. prose—

**Correct Answer: D**

**Rationale**

Choice D is the best answer. “A combination of fiction and memoir, poetry and prose” is a nonessential supplement, so it needs to be set off from the rest of the sentence with a pair of matching punctuation marks. We already have a dash at the beginning of the supplement, so we need to add a dash at the end of the supplement to match.

Choice A is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. “A combination of fiction and memoir, poetry and prose” is a nonessential supplement, so it needs to be set off from the rest of the sentence with a pair of matching punctuation marks. We already have a dash at the beginning of the supplement, so we need to add a dash at the end of the supplement to match. Choice B is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. “A combination of fiction and memoir, poetry and prose” is a nonessential supplement, so it needs to be set off from the rest of the sentence with a pair of matching punctuation marks. We already have a dash at the beginning of the supplement, so we need to add a dash at the end of the supplement to match. Choice C is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. “A combination of fiction and memoir, poetry and prose” is a nonessential supplement, so it needs to be set off from the rest of the sentence with a pair of matching punctuation marks. We already have a dash at the beginning of the supplement, so we need to add a dash at the end of the supplement to match.

# Question ID: c8540a5b

| Assessment | Test | Domain | Skill | Difficulty |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| SAT | Reading and Writing | Standard English Conventions | Boundaries | Medium |

**Question**

Swedish scientists Eva Engvall and Peter Perlmann developed a method for measuring the concentration of different proteins in a biological sample. Their _____ ELISA (enzyme-linked immunosorbent assay), is used to detect and measure proteins that indicate the presence of certain diseases.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

**Answer**

A. method (called

B. method—called

C. method, called

D. method called

**Correct Answer: C**

**Rationale**

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of a supplementary element within a sentence. The comma after "method" pairs with the comma after the closing parenthesis to separate the supplementary element "called ELISA (enzyme-linked immunosorbent assay)" from the rest of the sentence. This supplementary element functions to identify the name of Engvall and Perlmann's method, and the pair of commas indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because an opening parenthesis can't be paired with a comma to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice B is incorrect because a dash can't be paired with a comma to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence.

# Question ID: c101fc44

| Assessment | Test | Domain | Skill | Difficulty |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| SAT | Reading and Writing | Standard English Conventions | Boundaries | Medium |

**Question**

How do scientists determine what foods were eaten by extinct hominins such as Neanderthals? In the past, researchers were limited to studying the marks found on the fossilized teeth of skeletons, but in 2017 a team led by Laura Weyrich of the Australian Centre for Ancient DNA tried something _____ the DNA found in Neanderthals' fossilized dental plaque.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

**Answer**

A. new: sequencing

B. new; sequencing

C. new, sequencing:

D. new. Sequencing

**Correct Answer: A**

**Rationale**

Choice A is the best answer. "A team…tried something new" is an independent clause leading to an explanation of what the new thing was. A colon can only be used at the end of an independent clause, and typically introduces further explanation that expands upon the first clause, which makes a colon the perfect choice here.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice results in a punctuation error. "Sequencing…dental plaque" can't stand on its own as a sentence, and so it can't be linked to the independent clause "a team…tried something new" with a semicolon. Only two independent clauses can be connected in this way. Choice C is incorrect. This choice results in a punctuation error. If "sequencing" is included in the first clause, it can no longer stand on its own as a complete idea. Since a colon can only come at the end of an independent clause, using one in this way creates an error. Choice D is incorrect. This choice results in a sentence fragment. "Sequencing…dental plaque" can't stand on its own as a sentence.

# Question ID: a427a52c

| Assessment | Test | Domain | Skill | Difficulty |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| SAT | Reading and Writing | Standard English Conventions | Boundaries | Medium |

**Question**

The Lion Light system, developed by Kenyan inventor Richard Turere, consists of LED lights installed around the perimeter of livestock pastures. Powered with _____ the blinking LEDs keep lions away at night, thus protecting the livestock without risking harm to the endangered lions.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

**Answer**

A. energy collected, by solar panels, during the day

B. energy collected by solar panels during the day

C. energy collected by solar panels during the day,

D. energy, collected by solar panels during the day,

**Correct Answer: C**

**Rationale**

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between a supplementary phrase and a main clause. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the supplementary phrase (“powered…day”), which describes how the LEDs are powered, and the main clause (“the blinking…night”).

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the supplementary phrase and the main clause with appropriate punctuation. Furthermore, placing commas around the phrase “by solar panels” suggests that it could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn’t the case. Choice B is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the supplementary phrase and the main clause with appropriate punctuation. Choice D is incorrect. Placing commas around the phrase “collected by solar panels during the day" suggests that it could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn’t the case.

# Question ID: c04e9136

| Assessment | Test | Domain | Skill | Difficulty |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| SAT | Reading and Writing | Standard English Conventions | Boundaries | Medium |

**Question**

The 2022 Nobel Prize in Chemistry was awarded to three pioneers in the field of click chemistry: two-time Nobel laureate Barry Sharpless, who coined the term “click chemistry” in 1998; Carolyn Bertozzi, founder of the Bertozzi Group at _____ and Morten Meldal, a professor at the University of Copenhagen in Denmark.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

**Answer**

A. Stanford

B. Stanford,

C. Stanford:

D. Stanford;

**Correct Answer: D**

**Rationale**

Choice D is the best answer. This choice correctly uses a semicolon to punctuate a complex list (which is made up of items that have commas in them).

Choice A is incorrect. This is a complex list, indicated by the semicolon between "1998" and "Carolyn Bertozzi." What comes after the blank is a separate list item, so punctuation is needed after "Stanford." Choice B is incorrect. This is a complex list, indicated by the semicolon between "1998" and "Carolyn Bertozzi." The items in this list have internal punctuation in the form of commas and must therefore be separated by semicolons to avoid confusion. Choice C is incorrect. This is a complex list, indicated by the semicolon between "1998" and "Carolyn Bertozzi." Colons aren’t used to separate items in a list.

# Question ID: fe41f258

| Assessment | Test | Domain | Skill | Difficulty |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| SAT | Reading and Writing | Standard English Conventions | Boundaries | Medium |

**Question**

In ancient Greece, an Epicurean was a follower of Epicurus, a philosopher whose beliefs revolved around the pursuit of pleasure. Epicurus defined pleasure as “the absence of pain in the body and of trouble in the _____ that all life’s virtues derived from this absence.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

**Answer**

A. soul,” positing

B. soul”: positing

C. soul”; positing

D. soul.” Positing

**Correct Answer: A**

**Rationale**

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a main clause and a participial phrase. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the main clause (“Epicurus…‘soul’”) and the participial phrase (“positing…absence”) that provides additional information about how Epicurus defined pleasure.

Choice B is incorrect because a colon can’t be used in this way to join a main clause and a participial phrase. Choice C is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join a main clause and a participial phrase. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “positing.”

# Question ID: 3ed5ebb4

| Assessment | Test | Domain | Skill | Difficulty |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| SAT | Reading and Writing | Standard English Conventions | Boundaries | Medium |

**Question**

In her analysis of Edith Wharton's *The House of Mirth* (1905), scholar Candace Waid observes that the novel depicts the upper classes of New York society as "consumed by the appetite of a soulless _____ an apt assessment given that *The House of Mirth* is set during the Gilded Age, a period marked by rapid industrialization, economic greed, and widening wealth disparities.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

**Answer**

A. materialism"; and

B. materialism" and

C. materialism,"

D. materialism"

**Correct Answer: C**

**Rationale**

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between a main clause and a supplementary noun phrase. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the main clause ("scholar…materialism") and the supplementary noun phrase ("an apt assessment") that describes Waid's observation about how *The House of Mirth* depicts the upper classes of New York society.

Choice A is incorrect because a semicolon and the conjunction "and" can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between a main clause and a supplementary noun phrase. Choice B is incorrect. Joining the main clause ("scholar…materialism") and the following noun phrase with the conjunction "and" results in a confusing and illogical sentence that suggests that the novel depicts the upper classes of New York society as "an apt assessment," which doesn't make sense in this context. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the main clause and the supplementary noun phrase with appropriate punctuation.